Providing access to EMI learning resources

Practical guide for institutions | I06

Establish the services, resources and support that enable students and staff to access and use materials for learning through English. Institutional planning should address format, language, cost, connectivity and specialist assistance while maintaining disciplinary outcomes and standards.

Using this guide: Build these actions into existing library, digital learning, accessibility, procurement and course-material review processes. Educators select and explain disciplinary materials; institutional leaders and services establish expectations, provide the necessary infrastructure and expertise, and resolve barriers beyond individual educators' control.

1. Assign ownership and agree access expectations

Name the program and service roles responsible for essential readings, digital platforms, software, accessibility and technical support. Agree expectations for availability, usable formats, maintenance and reporting problems.

Specify what course teams must check and what help services will provide. Include resource access in normal course approval and review, with clear responsibility for unresolved gaps.

2. Plan and fund essential provision

Work with course teams to identify required resources, when they are needed and the licences, accounts, equipment and specialist capacity involved. Confirm funding and access arrangements before students depend on the resource.

Review costs to students, off-campus access, common devices and connectivity demands. Consult students privately about barriers; do not assume ethnic-minority identity indicates a particular level of digital competence or access.

3. Provide accessible systems and specialist assistance

Set clear expectations for navigable documents and platforms, meaningful headings and links, suitable text alternatives, and accessible media. Provide staff guidance, templates and access to accessibility or digital-learning specialists.

Arrange practical support for captions, transcripts and descriptions of essential visual information where needed. Allocate responsibility and time for checking automated outputs, including subject terminology. Educators should not have to solve technical accessibility problems without institutional assistance.

4. Resource language access and appropriate adaptation

Enable course teams to work with language specialists and library or learning-support staff on vocabulary guidance, unfamiliar references and the language demands of essential materials. Provide time and resources for adaptation while retaining disciplinary requirements.

Where needs justify it, arrange checked multilingual glossaries or supplementary explanations in relevant ethnic-minority languages. Vietnamese may also help but should not be assumed to be everyone's strongest language. Agree who checks meaning and how students can raise uncertainties; do not rely on classmates as unpaid interpreters.

Communicate institutional and course rules on translation, digital assistance and assessment. Support course teams to explain permitted use and follow approved adjustments and any explicit English-language outcomes.

5. Establish alternatives and orientation

Ensure a clear route for students to obtain help with platforms and locate materials. Coordinate orientation across library, IT and program teams so that unfamiliarity with a platform is addressed without assumptions about general digital competence.

Plan suitable alternatives where devices, connectivity or format create barriers: for example, smaller downloadable files, accessible text, campus equipment or an appropriate offline option. Confirm permissions and equivalent access to the essential learning task.

6. Maintain provision and resolve recurring barriers

Use service and course checks to test student permissions, links and common access routes before resources are needed and when platforms change. Publish a straightforward reporting route and agree who coordinates a response.

Review recurring access problems and unresolved requests through existing service and program review. Assign resources and review dates to systemic improvements rather than relying on repeated classroom workarounds.

7. Example coordinating access across a program

Several courses rely on streamed recordings. Students report unreliable access, and staff identify errors in automated captions. Course teams have been creating separate workarounds without technical support or an agreed standard.

The program lead coordinates with digital learning, IT and accessibility staff to establish a shared response. The institution allocates technical assistance and time for subject checks, provides suitable downloadable or accessible alternatives, and confirms student access. Course teams retain responsibility for disciplinary accuracy and task guidance.

The next service and program review checks whether students can use the resources and whether recurring problems are resolved. Unmet needs inform funding and procurement decisions.

8. Review checklist

☐ Resource and service responsibilities are explicit.

☐ Essential licences, equipment and assistance are planned and funded.

☐ Staff have accessible templates, guidance and specialist support.

☐ Language access includes consideration of relevant ethnic-minority languages.

☐ Students have orientation, help routes and suitable alternatives.

☐ Recurring problems inform service and program decisions.

9. When further institutional action is needed

Escalate unavailable essential materials, inaccessible platforms and insufficient specialist capacity to the responsible program or service lead. Agree an interim response and resource a lasting solution. Individual educators and students should not be left to compensate indefinitely for a lack of institutional provision.

10.Related toolkit guidance

I01: program review. I02: identifying students' needs. I03: support pathways. I05: staff development. I07: responsibilities. I08: monitoring. Educator guides D02–D05, D09 and D14 provide practical classroom applications.

11.Supporting sources

World Wide Web Consortium, Web Accessibility Initiative. (n.d.). Writing for Web Accessibility. Open source

Supports meaningful headings, links, text alternatives and clear instructions. It addresses web accessibility, not the complete EMI resource-access process.

World Wide Web Consortium, Web Accessibility Initiative. (2024). Making Audio and Video Media Accessible. Open source

Provides guidance on planning captions, transcripts and description of essential visual information. The guide applies these principles to course resources.

Galloway, N., & Sahan, K. (2021). An investigation into English Medium Instruction in higher education in Thailand and Vietnam. British Council. Open source

Section 9, "The EMI curriculum" (p. 42), discusses adapting materials to local needs. Applying this to ethnic-minority language access and resource checks is a toolkit adaptation.

The steps, example and checklist are toolkit adaptations for Vietnamese higher education. Sources support particular principles rather than the complete guide. The focus on ethnic-minority students and languages requires local consultation and evaluation. Developing draft for review; this is not a validated assessment or audit instrument.